region fits with its other initiatives to establish control over Asian trade routes, such as its massive investment in Karachi, Pakistan.[124]

Myanmar's formal move towards democracy has led to increasing contacts between the Burmese leadership and the US. Hillary Clinton visited in November 2011, and British Prime Minister David Cameron followed soon afterwards. This led to British and US pressure to lift EU and UN sanctions in 2012. That year also saw visits to the country from Tony Blair, EU Commission President José Manuel Barroso and, in November, President Obama (this visit coincided with the announcement of an independent inquiry into events in Rakhine). In all the international rivalries and competition for trade, the plight of the Rohingyas is easily overlooked. President Obama did mention the 2012 massacres in Rakhine when he visited, but this was one sentence in a speech that otherwise concentrated on praising the military and the opposition for managing the transition to democracy.

The EU has been another international actor with interests in Myanmar. It imposed sanctions after the 1990 crackdown, but since 2011 it has clearly decided that encouraging the regime is the only valid strategy.[125] As we shall see, it was very quick to absolve the regime of any responsibility in the 2012 ethnic violence in Rakhine[126] and subsequently lifted all its sanctions (apart from those connected to arms sales).[127] Since then it has been a major donor, in particular of help that it believes will assist the transition to full democracy.[128] Pragmatically, compared with the US, India and China, the EU is a minor actor in Myanmar, but it does set the tone of the response of the international community. As we will see, there are strong grounds for arguing that this belief in a gradual but inevitable transition to democracy that will benefit all the citizens of Myanmar is flawed.[129]

The US is clearly unhappy about the continued North Korean presence, but the fact that the Myanmar regime seems content to ignore this is indicative of its strong resistance to influence.[130]

Another important set of external relations is with ASEAN. This regional grouping tends to emphasise the concept of non-interference in members' affairs. This has led to an unwillingness to criticise Myanmar even if, mostly due to a range of territorial disputes, Myanmar has rarely played an active role in the group. An important reward for the relatively